

in the world compared with other emerging market economies. Our currency, our foreign exchange reserves, our stock markets, our macroeconomic fundamentals are the best. The world recognises this. The world wants to come and work in India. The world wants to work with India's 1.4 billion strong young, dynamic, enterprising, aspirational citizens. They recognise the talent and skill of young India. India has a very bright future. It is a matter of shame that the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha is parroting a negative narrative. I condemn him for that. And frankly, the nation will never forgive Rahul Gandhi for the demeaning comments about the great story that Bharat is demonstrating to the world.

SZ: India is currently engaged in trade negotiations with several countries. How many free trade agreements will we have by 2047?

A: India is much stronger today, much more self-confident, much more respected. We have a decisive leader in PM Modi, who is among the tallest and most respected leaders in the world. Today, we are a country that produces the highest number of STEM (science, technology, engineering and mathematics) graduates every year. We are a country already growing at 6.5% a year, and this will only get better in the years to come. We will, of course, have trading arrangements with other nations with whom we have complementarity, rather than concluding agreements like those done under the previous United Progressive Alliance regime, which did not help Indian business as much as they should have. On the contrary, if you look at our trade agreements, even business in India cannot find fault with them. We have agreements or dialogues with the UAE, Mauritius, Australia, the four-nation EFTA bloc (Switzerland, Norway, Liechtenstein, and Iceland), the UK; we are in dialogue with many other countries—Oman, the EU, the US, Chile, Peru and many others; New Zealand and many others want to start engaging with us. The world recognises India's strengths, recognises our demographic advantages, and what 1.4 billion aspirational Indians bring to the table in terms of demand. The aggregate demand India has is huge. Why else do you think everybody wants trade or better market access in India?

SZ: There is a view in some quarters that we have given the UK too much access, opened government procurement and certain sectors like alcohol. How would you address such concerns?



“Whether it’s our farmers, livestock breeders, retail traders, small industries, entrepreneurs—the government takes care of their interests”

A: On government procurement, we have opened larger opportunities in the UK for Indian entrepreneurs, it is two-way traffic. Anyone expecting other nations to open markets to India without reciprocity is being unrealistic. The privileges accorded to the micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSME) sector remain intact; firms from the UK will only be class-two suppliers here. In return, restrictions in the UK won't apply to Indian companies, unlocking more access to public procurement there.

The UK trade deal took more than 20 years—two decades of lost opportunities—largely because of the opposition over importing alcoholic beverages, mainly Scotch whisky. In exchange for limited access